

Intervals in half steps

It is possible for different intervals to have the same number of half steps between their top and bottom notes. Intervals that span the same number of half steps will have different names (qualities) depending on how they are written on the staff.

▽ Intervals

This table shows the number of half steps between all of the different possible simple intervals. Both the size and quality of the intervals determine the number of half steps.

Quality \ Size	Unison	2 nd	3 rd	4 th	5 th	6 th	7 th	Octave (8ve)
Augmented	1	3	5	6	8	10	12	13
Major		2	4			9	11	
Perfect	0			5	7			12
Minor		1	3			8	10	
Diminished	-1	0	2	4	6	7	9	11

No interval

4 half steps
Major 3rd

8 half steps
Minor 6th

5 half steps
Perfect 4th

3 half steps
Augmented 2nd

6 half steps
Diminished 5th

△ **On the staff**
Shown above are examples of five different qualities of intervals and the number of half steps between them.

Compound intervals

Intervals of an augmented octave or less are known as simple intervals. The intervals that are bigger than an augmented octave are known as compound intervals. Compound intervals can be broken down into a perfect octave and a given simple interval.

Octave + simple interval = compound interval
(8ve) (5th) (12th or compound 5th)

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▷ Compound 5th

Shown here on the staff, a compound 5th can be broken down into a perfect 8ve and a perfect 5th.

Perfect 5th

Compound 5th

Perfect 8ve

Perfect 8ve + perfect 5th = compound 5th

Combination	Interval
Octave + 2 nd =	Compound 2 nd (9 th)
Octave + 3 rd =	Compound 3 rd (10 th)
Octave + 4 th =	Compound 4 th (11 th)
Octave + 5 th =	Compound 5 th (12 th)
Octave + 6 th =	Compound 6 th (13 th)
Octave + 7 th =	Compound 7 th (14 th)
Octave + 8 th =	Double octave (15 th)

△ Interval combinations

Simple intervals are combined with a perfect octave to make compound intervals. The alternative names for these compound intervals are also shown in this table.